

The logo for the University Medical Center Groningen (UMCG), consisting of the lowercase letters 'umcg' in a bold, blue, sans-serif font.

University Medical Center Groningen - Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) Action Plan

Introduction

The UMCG CoARA Action Plan outlines the institution's approach to implementing the commitments and principles of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA). It provides a framework for revising research assessment practices, emphasizing inclusivity, transparency, and alignment with broader institutional and disciplinary goals.

UMCG builds on a strong foundation of ongoing efforts in recognition and rewards, as reflected in its [Recognition and Rewards program](#), and its commitment to [open science](#). These initiatives align closely with the principles of the University of Groningen's [Open Science Program](#), providing a well-established basis for further development. These existing efforts demonstrate the institution's long-standing engagement with practices that aim to enhance equity, diversity, and the responsible use of metrics in research evaluation.

The Action Plan serves as a structured document to formalize and advance these initiatives, recognizing the need for continuous review and adaptation. It integrates existing policies, such as the Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP), the Leiden Manifesto, and the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA), into a coherent strategy. UMCG's approach acknowledges the complexities of reform and commits to iterative development informed by evidence and stakeholder engagement at all career stages.

This document reflects UMCG's ongoing commitment to refining research assessment practices while fostering a collaborative and sustainable academic culture.

The CoARA action plan

CoARA Commitment	UMCG Actions and Current Status
1. Recognize diversity of contributions and careers in research	- Developed four impact profiles for academic promotion (e.g., Research, Education, Society & Valorization and Translational research for Health Care).
	- Emphasis on diversified career paths and exploration of team recognition.
	- Enhancing career paths focused on education and societal impact to make them align fully with the national Recognition & Rewards programme.
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation supported by responsible quantitative indicators	- Modified promotion criteria to focus on qualitative evaluation, quantitative evaluations use responsible metrics and are always accompanied by qualitative explanation.
	- Signed DORA and CoARA declarations.
	- Addressing differences in academic fields for qualitative assessment.
3. Avoid inappropriate use of journal metrics (e.g., JIF, h-index)	- The UMCG does not use any journal metrics anymore. Commitment to reducing emphasis on other bibliometric indicators.
	- Developed promotion and funding criteria always supported by qualitative assessments.
4. Avoid use of research organization rankings in assessment	- No reliance on rankings in assessments.
	- Policies and guidelines in alignment with CoARA and Recognition & Rewards goals.
5. Commit resources to reform research assessment	- Formation of working groups for implementation of goals.
	- HR and research office involvement in managing process and milestones.

	- Project manager coordinating working groups and processes
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria and processes	- Review research assessment criteria ongoing.
	- Exploration of guidelines for team contributions without losing focus on individual achievements.
	- Ongoing improvements through learning from institutions like Maastricht University, Wageningen University and Twente University.
7. Raise awareness and provide training on assessment criteria and processes	- Training through the Leadership@UMCG program.
	- Communication plan and workshops to align staff with Recognition & Rewards initiatives.
8. Exchange practices and experiences for mutual learning	- Participation in Recognition & Rewards events.
	- Collaboration within the national chapter and among Dutch universities and university medical centers and within UMC specific R&R working group.
9. Communicate progress on commitments	- Active communication through intranet pages, workshops, and online platforms.
	- Emphasis on transparency and engagement with the academic community.
10. Evaluate practices and make data openly available for evidence gathering	- Monitoring outcomes through initiatives like Cultuurbarometer.
	- Focus on open science and data sharing in alignment with Koers25.